

SMM Iron Ore Daily

2026-10-01 Thursday · Imported & Domestic Ore · Prices · Supply-Demand · Inventory · Commentary

Source **SMM Data-pro**

Futures Contracts		Closing price
SGX Iron Ore Most-traded Contract Daily		
93.50 USD/dmt		
▼ -1.36 -1.43%		
MTD avg 97.19		
As of Sep 30 · vs Sep 29		
DCE Iron Ore Most-traded 12701 Daily		
702.5 yuan/mt		
▲ +3.5 +0.50%		
MTD avg 717.4		
Closed for the National Day holiday · close as of Sep 30		

SMM Iron Ore Price Index		Seaborne as of Oct 1 · port spot not quoted
MMi 61% Port Spot Daily		
674 yuan/wmt		
No quotation (holiday)		
as of 09-30		
MTD avg 692		
MMi 58% Port Spot Daily		
638 yuan/wmt		
No quotation (holiday)		
as of 09-30		
MTD avg 647		
MMi 65% Port Spot Daily		
838 yuan/wmt		
No quotation (holiday)		
as of 09-30		
MTD avg 840		
SMM 61% Seaborne Index Daily		
93.00 USD/dmt		
▼ -1.20 -1.27%		
MTD avg 93.00		
SMM 65% Seaborne Index Daily		
111.75 USD/dmt		
▼ -0.25 -0.22%		
MTD avg 111.75		
SMM Domestic Ore Composite Index Daily		
831.59 yuan/mt		
▼ -5.86 -0.70%		
MTD avg 840.09		
Index as of Sep 24 · vs Sep 23		

Key View

Day one with China closed: offshore markets priced the holiday, every seaborne fines brand bar IOCJ fell, and yet import losses narrowed to 2.45 yuan

On the first day of the National Day holiday every domestic price basis went dark at once — **the DCE is shut and neither yuan spot nor the three port spot indices were quoted**. Those fields in this report carry their last Sep 30 values and are marked accordingly. The only market actually trading was the seaborne one, and its signal is clear enough: **the MMi 61% seaborne index fell to USD 93.00/dmt (-1.27%) and the 65% to 111.75 (-0.22%)**, with **only IOCJ holding at 112.00** among the 12 mainstream seaborne fines; everything else lost USD 1.05-1.60. The distribution of those declines matters more than their size. Low grades fell hardest — SPI0 -1.94%, RTX Fines -1.75%, Jimblebar Blended Fines -1.73% — mainstream PB Fines lost just 1.11%, and 65% IOCJ did not move at all. **This is not a sell-off in high-grade demand; it is a sell-off in holiday liquidity**. Low grades depend more on domestic speculative and trade flows, so when China stops, their bid disappears first; high grades sit behind long-term contracts and the base blast furnace blend and hold up best through a break. The high-low spread therefore widened again on day one — the other side of the same coin as the port spot spread reaching 200 yuan/wmt on Sep 30. Offshore markets had in fact moved early: **on Sep 30 the DCE rose 0.50% while SGX fell 1.43%**. The two boards diverged because the domestic one was pricing pre-holiday sentiment and the offshore one was pricing post-holiday reality. Costs cut the other way: **the average imported ore loss narrowed from 6.12 to 2.45 yuan/mt**, an improvement of 3.67 yuan from a modest spot rise, a stronger yuan and lower freight combined. Our previous issue wrote that the first print after the holiday could recover ground; it has. But keep it in perspective: of the three drivers, **the exchange rate reflects neither ore strength nor mill profitability**, and if the yuan gives back ground the improvement goes with it. SMM still expects imported ore to run a modest loss. On inventories, Sep 30 brought the 10-port total to 103.02 million mt (+430,000 mt), but **fines drew down** (-77,100 mt) while lump (+284,200), pellets (+155,500) and concentrates (+59,900) built. Mills squeezing expensive supplementary feed while protecting the base blend says more than the headline total. On balance, direction during the break is set offshore and no new fundamentals are in play. **Three things on the first session back will determine how far the domestic market has to catch down**: the actual size of October's first hot metal decline, whether the first round of coke cuts lands, and how much ground offshore markets have lost over the eight days.

Today's Highlights

- China is on an eight-day National Day holiday, so pricing passes to the overseas market. With the domestic market closed from Oct 1 to Oct 8, **yuan-denominated spot, the three port spot indices and the DCE board are all unquoted** (the tables carry their last values from Sep 30). The seaborne market traded as usual: the SMM MMi **61% seaborne index fell to USD 93.00/dmt** (-1.20, -1.27%) and the **65% to 111.75** (-0.25, -0.22%).
- Every seaborne fines brand fell except IOCJ, and low grades fell hardest. Of the 12 mainstream seaborne fines, **only IOCJ held at USD 112.00/dmt**; the rest lost USD 1.05-1.60. Low grades led the way down — SPI0 -1.94%, RTX Fines -1.75%, Jimblebar Blended Fines -1.73% — while mainstream mid grades fell less (PB Fines -1.11%, Newman and Mac Fines -1.28%) and the two Brazilian fines dropped around 1.5%. **The high-low spread widened further on day one of the holiday**, which is also why the 61% index fell almost six times as much as the 65%.
- Import losses narrowed sharply, vindicating last issue's basis note. SMM puts the average imported ore loss at **2.45 yuan/mt, down from 6.12**, attributing the improvement to **a modest rise in spot prices, a stronger yuan and lower ocean freight**. Our Sep 30 issue flagged that the table referenced Sep 29 data while that day's spot recovery and further freight decline "both point mechanically to margin repair" — this print delivers exactly that.
- Port stocks built again, but the mix is diverging. SMM's 10-port total reached **103.02 million mt** on Sep 30, up 430,000 mt WoW; **fines drew down** to 82.275 million mt (-77,100 mt) while lump rose 284,200 mt, pellets 155,500 mt and concentrates 59,900 mt. SMM also notes that **arrivals are expected to increase somewhat this week, sustaining a high-inventory, comfortably supplied market**.

Qingdao Port Imported Ore Spot Prices

yuan/wet mt · tax incl. · market closed for the National Day holiday (Oct 1-8); last prices as of 2026-09-30

Product	10-01 (yuan/wmt)	Daily change / %	MTD avg	Last 12 months
PB Fines 60.8% Daily	665	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	683	
Newman Fines 61.2% Daily	668	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	688	
Mac Fines 60.8% Daily	667	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	685	
BRBF 62.5% Daily	720	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	739	
Newman Lump 63% Daily	860	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	881	
Super Special Fines (SSF) 56.5% Daily	527	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	545	
Carajas Fines (IOCJ) 65% Daily	842	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	845	
PB Lump 61.5% Daily	860	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	878	

Imported Ore USD Prices & MMi Indices

USD/dry mt · upper table: port spot converted · lower table: seaborne (CFR Qingdao) traded brands

USD prices (port spot converted) no quotations during the holiday; last prices as of 2026-09-30

Product	10-01 (USD/dmt)	Daily change / %	MTD avg	Last 12 months
Carajas Fines (IOCJ) 65% Daily	116.54	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	116.14	
PB Lump 61.6% Daily	119.11	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	121.00	
BRBF 62.5% Daily	99.12	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	101.22	
Newman Fines 61.2% Daily	91.69	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	93.96	
Mac Fines 61% Daily	91.55	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	93.49	
Jimblebar Fines 60.5% Daily	89.55	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	90.64	
FMG Blend Fines 58.5% Daily	87.26	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	88.23	
Newman Lump 63% Daily	119.11	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	121.46	
Super Special Fines (SSF) 57% Daily	71.55	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	73.54	
Indian Fines 57% Daily	66.98	No quotation (holiday) as of 09-30	69.18	

Seaborne Fines Prices in USD · CFR Qingdao · quoted as usual through the holiday				
Product	10-01 (USD/dmt)	Daily change / %	09-30	
Carajas Fines (IOCJ) Daily	112.00	— 0.00 0.00%	112.00	
Brazilian Blend Fines Daily	101.35	▼ -1.50 -1.46%	102.85	
Brazilian SSF Daily	100.80	▼ -1.60 -1.56%	102.40	
PB Fines Daily	93.25	▼ -1.05 -1.11%	94.30	
West Pilbara Fines (WPF) Daily	92.45	▼ -1.25 -1.33%	93.70	
Newman Fines Daily	92.30	▼ -1.20 -1.28%	93.50	
Mac Fines Daily	92.30	▼ -1.20 -1.28%	93.50	
SIMEC Fines Daily	90.60	▼ -1.25 -1.36%	91.85	
Roy Hill Fines Daily	89.60	▼ -1.25 -1.38%	90.85	
Jimblebar Blended Fines Daily	87.90	▼ -1.55 -1.73%	89.45	
RTX Fines Daily	87.15	▼ -1.55 -1.75%	88.70	
SPI0 Fines Daily	78.55	▼ -1.55 -1.94%	80.10	

SMM Iron Ore Price Index weekly / monthly statistics

Index	Month-to-date avg	MoM	YTD	Unit	Last 12 months
SMM MMi 61% Iron Ore Seaborne Index Daily	93.00	-3.63%	-12.2%	USD/dmt	
SMM MMi 65% Iron Ore Seaborne Index Daily	111.75	-2.34%	-7.9%	USD/dmt	
SMM MMi 61% Iron Ore Port Spot Index Daily	692	+0.33%	-17.1%	yuan/wmt	
SMM MMi 65% Iron Ore Port Spot Index Daily	840	+0.78%	-6.8%	yuan/wmt	
SMM MMi 58% Iron Ore Port Spot Index Daily	647	+1.30%	-11.1%	yuan/wmt	
SMM China Domestic Ore Composite Price Index Daily	840.09	-0.11%	-6.2%	yuan/mt	

China is on an eight-day National Day holiday (Oct 1-8), so the three port spot indices were not quoted and the table carries their last values from Sep 30. The two seaborne indices published as usual: the 61% at **USD 93.00/dmt** (-1.20, -1.27%) and the 65% at **USD 111.75** (-0.25, -0.22%). The near sixfold gap between those declines matches the seaborne brand quotes below — IOCJ held at 112.00 while mid- and low-grade fines fell USD 1.05-1.60, widening the high-low spread further on day one of the holiday.

* SMM quotations for Newman Fines and PB Lump (both CNY and USD) start in Mar 2026; their sparklines cover that shorter window only. All others show the past year.

Key Price Drivers

Last 12 months

Iron Ore Ocean Freight USD/mt · daily · last 12M · C3 Tubarao→Beilun/Baoshan, C5 W. Australia Dampier→Qingdao/Beilun/Baoshan 	Iron Ore Port Inventory at 10 Ports · by Product Left: fines Right: concentrates / lump / pellets · 10,000 mt · weekly
Daily Avg Hot Metal Output & BF Operating Rate, 242 Mills Left: 10,000 mt Right: % · weekly 	Global Iron Ore Shipments vs Arrivals at Chinese Ports 10,000 mt · weekly · shipments 123 ports / arrivals 61 ports

Market Commentary · Imported Ore

Futures & spot	The domestic market is closed. China's eight-day National Day holiday runs Oct 1-8, the DCE is shut, and neither Qingdao port yuan spot nor the three port spot indices were quoted; those fields are marked "no quotation (holiday)" in this report and carry their last Sep 30 values (DCE 702.5 yuan/mt, PB Fines 665 yuan/wmt, MMi 61% port spot 674 yuan/wmt). Offshore markets kept trading : SGX most-traded settled at USD 93.50/dmt on Sep 30, down 1.43% on the day — the opposite direction to the DCE's +0.50% that same session. On Oct 1 the seaborne indices extended their decline, with the MMi 61% at 93.00 (-1.27%) and the 65% at 111.75 (-0.22%). Basis note : "prices as of Oct 1" applies only to seaborne products; the effective cut-off for yuan spot and port spot is Sep 30.
Drivers	The holiday is itself the main driver this issue. SMM states plainly that China is entering an eight-day National Day holiday, liquidity may thin out during the break, and iron ore prices should stay soft and choppy near term . Offshore markets priced that risk first: SGX fell 1.43% on Sep 30 and seaborne fines fell 1-2% on Oct 1. No new bearish fundamentals emerged — hot metal, maintenance and shipment figures all carry over from Sep 30 — but no new bullish ones did either: the first round of coke price cuts remains rumour, to be tested after the holiday.
Demand	No new demand data this issue; the Sep 30 prints still stand. Daily average hot metal across 242 mills was 2.3882 million mt (-6,100 mt WoW), the blast furnace operating rate 88.57% (-0.19 ppt) and capacity utilisation 88.15% (-0.18 ppt) — a fourth consecutive weekly decline from the 2.4080 million mt peak on Sep 2, with the last three drops widening from 3,700 to 4,800 to 6,100 mt . SMM's forward guidance still holds: with mills loss-making, some report they will draw up maintenance plans in early October and overall hot metal output may fall markedly . Maintenance losses are 1.6288 million mt this week (Sep 26-Oct 2) and a projected 1.6839 million next (Oct 3-9). The first hot metal print after the holiday is the key test of this cycle .
Inventory & supply	Port stocks were updated to Sep 30. SMM's 10-port total reached 103.02 million mt, up 430,000 mt WoW, but the mix diverged: fines drew down to 82.275 million mt (-77,100 mt) while lump rose to 10,8263 million (+284,200), pellets to 1.8894 million (+155,500) and concentrates to 8.0258 million (+59,900). Fines are the mainstay of the blast furnace burden, so a fines drawdown alongside a lump and pellet build looks like mills squeezing expensive supplementary feed while protecting the base blend as they cut output. SMM also flags that arrivals are expected to increase somewhat this week, sustaining a high-inventory, comfortably supplied market . Shipment and arrival figures are unchanged at 35,5121 million mt globally and 29,44625 million mt into China as of Sep 25; freight was last published Sep 29 at USD 40.26/mt for C3 and USD 14.13/mt for C5.
Cost & margin	The biggest change this issue. SMM puts the average imported ore loss at 2.45 yuan/mt, down from 6.12 — an improvement of 3.67 yuan driven by three forces pulling the same way: a modest rise in spot prices, a stronger yuan and lower ocean freight . Our Sep 30 issue flagged a tension in that table — it referenced Sep 29 spot and freight, whereas on Sep 30 port spot recovered and freight fell another 4-6%, both of which mechanically repair margins, so the first print after the holiday could recover ground. This is that recovery. One caveat: the currency is the least controllable of the three — it reflects neither ore strength nor mill profitability, and if the yuan gives back ground after the holiday, that part of the improvement disappears with it. SMM's view remains that imported ore will keep running a modest loss .

Market Commentary · Domestic Ore

Prices	The domestic ore market is closed for the National Day holiday, so there were no new quotations . The SMM China Domestic Ore Composite Price Index still reads 831.59 yuan/mt (as of Sep 24, -0.70%). The last brief before the break covered eastern Liaoning, where SMM expects local iron ore prices to trade range-bound near term .
Supply & demand	Two monthly series landed this issue: national iron ore concentrate output of 18.87 million mt in September 2026 and national concentrate inventory: 280,000 mt . Stocks remain low in absolute terms, consistent with the pre-holiday brief's description of low concentrator operating rates, generally tight supply and high holder costs. Weekly figures are unchanged at a 58.1% mine capacity utilisation rate (-0.1 ppt) and 898,000 mt of concentrate output (-2,000 mt) as of Sep 25.
Outlook	With no price discovery during the holiday, direction depends on three things on the first trading day back: the pace of mill restarts (gauged by whether early-October maintenance plans materialise), whether the first round of coke price cuts lands, and how much of the eight-day offshore decline the domestic market has to catch down to. Given tight domestic supply and a high share of contract volumes, domestic ore typically has less catch-down to do than imported ore.

Market Factors

▲ Supportive factors - The average imported ore loss narrowed sharply from 6.12 to 2.45 yuan/mt; cost still constrains the downside. - A stronger yuan and lower ocean freight both pulled landed costs down. - IOCJ held flat at USD 112.00/dmt on day one of the holiday; the high-grade end is holding its own. - Fines stocks at the 10 ports drew down 77,100 mt — the core blast furnace burden is not building. - Talk of a first round of coke price cuts persists; landing in early October would ease mill cost pressure. - Domestic supply is tight and September concentrate stocks were only 280,000 mt, supporting domestic prices.	▼ Bearish factors - SMM warns liquidity may thin over the eight-day holiday, keeping prices soft and choppy. - Every seaborne fines brand bar IOCJ fell, with SPI0 and RTX Fines down 1.8-1.9% in a single day. - SGX fell 1.43% on Sep 30, diverging from the DCE's gain the same session. - Hot metal fell a fourth straight week to 2.3882 million mt, with the decline widening each week. - SMM warns some mills will set maintenance plans in early October, with hot metal possibly falling markedly. - The 10-port total rose to 103.02 million mt, and SMM expects arrivals to increase this week.
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Flash News

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SMM Imported Iron Ore Cost & Margin Table, Oct 1, 2026 (average loss 6.12 → 2.45 yuan/mt)	↗
Iron Ore Inventory by Product at 10 Ports, Sep 30, 2026 (total 103.02 million mt, +430,000 mt WoW)	↗
China's National Iron Ore Concentrate Inventory, September 2026: 280,000 mt	↗
[SMM BF Operating Rate] Weaker mill production appetite as hot metal output keeps sliding (2.3882 million mt, -6,100 mt WoW)	↗
SMM Imported Ore Miner Discounts — October 2026 (Australia's big three diverge by product)	↗
[SMM Analysis] Behind the USD 15 billion Iowa steel plant plan: the real substance of institutionalised US steel trade barriers	↗

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